



# Digital Desi Music

Indian music going digital

If you swear by Hindi music, and want to download digital versions of Indian music, there's good news for you—downloading your favourite music will soon be easier. Music company, Saregama India has tied-up with Loudeye, a Seattle-based provider of media services, to distribute its music catalogue to online music stores globally.

And that's not all. More such tie-ups with US portals are likely to happen in the coming months, to offer digital downloads of Hindi music. The Indian Music Industry (IMI), the apex body of the nation's music companies, is also planning a Web site dedicated exclusively to Indian music.

## How it works

Napsterism has been with us for some time now, even if the original Napster hasn't been around. Since 2003, pay-per-download music is big. Web sites such as Apple's iTunes have tie-ups with record labels—these labels share their catalogues to be displayed online. One-song downloads at iTunes cost less than a dollar, and the money is shared between music companies and the artists. Royalties are based on the number of downloads a particular song sees. There is tremendous business potential here—Sony, Wal-Mart, and even MTV have jumped on the online-music pad.

## Why online music?

How many times you have bought an entire music CD, or cassette, just for one song? That's a major advantage of online music—you only pay for what you want. Web sites also allow you to burn CDs, share your playlists via e-mail, and import music to Windows Media Player, Music Match, and any other application that uses MP3, WMA or Advanced Audio Coding (AAC). And, as in the US, the cost for downloading a song in India will soon be far less than that of an audio cassette.

## The Indian music industry

Vijay Lazarus, President and Managing Director of Universal Music, feels it's an encouraging trend for the Indian music industry to gain international accessibility. Shridhar Subramaniam, MD, Sony Music India, believes this would be a demonstration of the global appeal of Indian music. Even Narendra Kusnur, music reviewer with *Mid Day*, a Mumbai-based daily, feels that availability of online Hindi music is a

good sign for an industry riddled with piracy and free music downloads.

Online music is almost 10 per cent of business for all global music companies.

Sony has already made its interna-

tional repertoire available to a number of content providers, and is available on a number of sites. The next phase is to digitise and make its global repertoire available. The Indian repertoire will be officially available by the end of 2004, on at least two networks, according to Subramaniam. Similarly, the IMI also plans on having an iTunes-like Web site that will be a one stop shop for a whole bunch of Hindi songs.

The IMI estimates that non-physical formats of music sales contribute five per cent to the bottom line of the music companies, and is likely to increase to as much as 30 per cent in the next three to five years.

## The future

The online Hindi music industry is in a nascent stage. But everyone is optimistic. As Subramaniam says, "The key task will be to get consumers to start paying for music online. This will come with only with a combination of the right pricing, ease of download, the right experience, and consumer awareness." With increased broadband penetration, online music seems all set to bring some happy tunes. 



Saregama India is set to be India's version of iTunes

## PEOPLE TO WATCH

In a company that indexes 4.5 billion Web pages, and employs hundreds of software engineers, you'd never expect to find a smiling Indian PhD with a penchant for news and journalism. However, India-born and Georgia Tech educated, Krishna Bharat is not an ordinary programmer. As Google's principal scientist, he developed Google News in 2003, a service that is as popular as the world's favourite search engine itself.

His latest assignment, however, is a lot closer to home—Krishna will head Google's first offshore development centre in Bangalore, which begins operations soon. India can now officially claim to be on the world's search algorithm map.

**Krishna Bharat,**  
HEAD, GOOGLE INDIA

